SWINBURNE UNIVERSITY OF TECHNOLOGY

Professional Placement (3-months)

Assignment 3 – Reflection: Workplace progress and feedback

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Instructions

This assignment consists of three sections. Use this template to structure and submit the assignment.

Section 1: Reflect on the actions you listed in Section1 of your Assignment 2 (Intention for learning). This reflection serves as a preparation for the Workplace progress and feedback meeting. Refer to the prompts listed in the assignment description on Canvas. Keep in mind the framework for reflection: What? So what? Now what?

Word Limit: 400 words

What?

Looking back at the nine "Now what" actions I set out across my three domains, the outcome is a genuine mix of delivered-as-planned, delivered-differently, and consciously dropped. In Knowledge in Practice, I did deploy a Python NLP microservice on AWS Lambda for emotion detection, but I built it as a self-contained DistilBERT (ONNX, quantised) model rather than a generic cloud service, and the planned Flutter/Drift offline-first client with a local sync-queue manager was abandoned entirely — partway through the placement I rebuilt the frontend as a cloud-only Nuxt web app, judging that conflict-resolution logic added more complexity than it returned for a single-user tool. The EventBridge nightly report cron job was also cut, replaced by an on-demand, client-side export the user triggers manually. In Innovation and Problem Solving, the pgvector similarity search and the secure Lambda-to-Postgres API layer were both delivered, though on a managed Supabase database rather than the self-hosted Postgres I had originally scoped, with in-Lambda token verification standing in for a more generic "secure API layer." The AI Agent itself became a full Bedrock-based conversational task assistant — well beyond what I had planned — but the SNS-triggered automated health-break notification was never built. In Self-Management and Professional Practice, wireframes and schema evolved iteratively through versioned SQL migrations instead of being finalised up front, and my "Weekly Project Log" became a single running technical changelog instead — but I never wrote automated tests or set up CI/CD, which is the one action that was simply not done rather than replaced by something better.

So what?

This showed me that the "Now what" actions I wrote in week one were hypotheses, not commitments, and that the real skill was making deliberate, documented trade-offs when reality diverged from the plan — not rigidly executing the original list. I am comfortable with most of the pivots because I can explain the reasoning behind each one. I am least comfortable with the testing/CI/CD gap, because that one was simply deprioritised under time pressure rather than replaced by a better alternative.

Now what?

Ahead of the progress meeting, I want to raise whether closing the testing/CI gap is worth prioritising in the remaining time, or whether continuing to deepen the AI features is more valuable. I also want to start logging scope changes at the moment I make them, not in hindsight, so my supervisors can weigh in while the decision is still open.

Section 2: Reflect on your workplace progress feedback.

What? What was the most important insight you gained from this meeting? This could be related to any of the domains of practice you were focusing your intention for learning on, alternatively, your insights may be related to the process of seeking and receiving feedback. You may consider if there are any changes to your initial intentions from Assignment 2.
So what? Think about why this insight is relevant to you right now.
Now what? What are some of the actions you want to pursue now?

Word Limit: 400 words

What?

The most important insight from my workplace progress meeting was confirmation that my current direction is sound, not a request to change course. Both my Industry and Academic Supervisors gave positive feedback on my progress, with no significant concerns raised. The one substantive point discussed was a change to my initial intention from Assignment 2: my original Knowledge in Practice focus assumed a mobile-first build using Flutter and Drift for offline-first storage, but by the time of the meeting I had already moved the project to a cloud-only Nuxt web application. Rather than being flagged as a deviation from the plan, this pivot was acknowledged as a legitimate adaptation — the meeting validated a decision I had already made, rather than prompting it.

So what?

This is relevant to me right now because it reframes how I think about the relationship between a stated learning intention and the actual trajectory of a real project. Assignment 2 asked me to commit to a mobile-focused technical direction in week one, before I had enough information about the trade-offs between an offline-first mobile architecture and a simpler cloud-native web approach. Receiving confirmation rather than correction reassured me that domain-level learning intentions, such as cloud-native architecture and serverless microservices, can remain valid even when the specific technology stack underneath them changes substantially. It also taught me something about the process of seeking feedback itself: because I proactively explained the reasoning behind the mobile-to-web pivot rather than waiting to be asked about it, the meeting became a confirmation exercise rather than a defensive one. Bringing my own critical reflection to a feedback meeting, instead of only presenting outcomes, seems to be what turns a status update into genuine mentorship.

Now what?

Going forward, I want to keep front-loading this kind of reasoning in future check-ins rather than only reporting what was built. Concretely, I will update my learning intention language to describe the web/cloud direction explicitly, rather than leaving the original mobile framing in place and treating the shift as an implicit footnote. I also want to use the remaining placement time to test whether the positive feedback holds once the harder-to-finish items — automated testing and CI/CD — are addressed, since those remain the most visible gap between my original intentions and current reality.

Section 3: Reflect on the two (or more) P2P debrief sessions you have had to date. What was the most valuable learning for you: **the process of the debriefing session** (you might highlight your observations of the different roles and approaches taken during the session) **OR the topics shared and the insights explored?** Provide brief details and explain why.

Word Limit: 200 words

What?

The most valuable part of the P2P debrief process for me was not the weekly session itself but what came out of escalating the discussion further. After debriefing with my peers each week, we proposed the project to the wider ITea Lab group so more people could debate it openly. That broader round of scrutiny produced substantive feedback that led to meaningful revisions — not just to structure, but to specific functionality and user cases within the app.

So what?

This mattered because peer feedback within a small, familiar debrief group can become comfortable and confirmatory. Opening the same material to a larger, less familiar audience surfaced gaps in the actual use cases my project was solving, gaps that the smaller weekly sessions had not caught.

Now what?

I want to keep using the weekly debrief as a first filter, but deliberately escalate anything I am uncertain about to a wider audience, such as ITea Lab, before treating it as settled, rather than assuming agreement within a smaller group is sufficient validation.